

Social and Pragmatic Interventions for the Neurodiversity-Affirming SLP

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Disclosures

- Financial:
 - I have no financial disclosures related to this presentation. I receive a salary from DeSales University.
- Non-financial:
 - I have no non-financial disclosures related to this presentation.

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Justifying social/pragmatic interventions in the neurodiversity-affirming paradigm

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Quote

"Not wanting to socialize is different from wanting to socialize and being unable to. Both are possibilities for autistic people. One requires acceptance, the other requires assistance. Sadly, I have yet to meet a therapist who doesn't treat the two as equivalent and in equal need of correction."

-DeThorne & Sears Smith

Autism and neurodiversity: Addressing concerns and offering implications for the school-based speech-language pathologist.

• https://pubs.asha.org/doi/full/10.1044/2020_PERSP-20-00188

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Premises

1. "Social skills" are behaviors
2. Social behaviors are normed around neurotypical characteristics
3. Autistic characteristics can't be *changed*, only suppressed
4. Teaching neurotypical behaviors requires suppression of autistic characteristics
5. Suppressing autistic characteristics is *awful* for mental health
6. ...And it's not even effective, anyway!

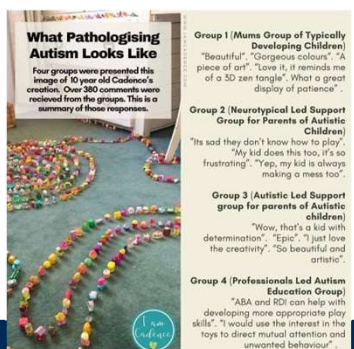
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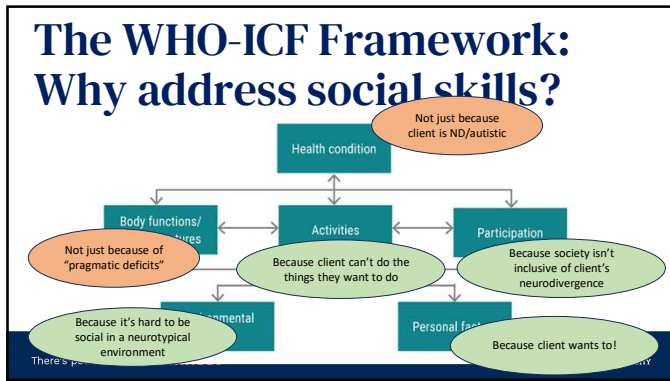
Contrasting models

- Medical model = pathologizing
 - Focus on normalization, treating deficits
 - "How can we fix you?"
- Social model = Judgment-free
 - Focus on supporting real needs
 - "How can we help you?"

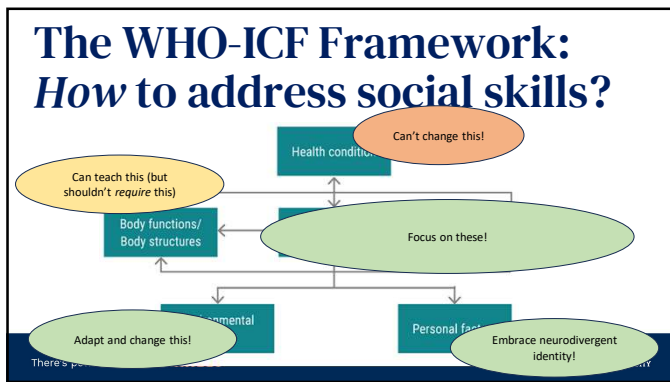


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Contrasting models

	"Traditional" social skills interventions	Neurodiversity-affirming perspectives
Context & Assumptions	- Social norms are objective and important "Normal" is good - Deviations from "normal" are undesirable, and should be corrected	- Social norms are constructs established by (and for) a mostly-neurotypical society, but are not inherently "better" than norms reflecting neurodivergent characteristics. - Enforcing social norms benefits others at the expense of oneself.
Purpose	"Normalization" - Interpreting perspectives	- Teaching strategies to improve access, participation, and self-advocacy - Navigating the double-empathy problem
Methods	- Dx: Standardized assessments - Tx: Social skills curricula, often featuring worksheets	- Dx: Multicomponent, using observation, questionnaires, interviews, assessments to address all areas of ICF framework - Tx: Contextualized and activity-based instruction

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Intervention framework

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Step 0: Prevention

- Scope of practice (per ASHA):
 - Advocacy & outreach
 - Prevention and wellness
- Implementation of prevention?
 - Teach from a “double-empathy” perspective
 - Good opportunity for RTI, in-class services, etc.

Professional practice domains:

- advocacy and outreach
- supervision
- education
- administration/leadership
- research

Service delivery domains

- Collaboration
- Counseling
- Prevention and Wellness
- Screening
- Assessment
- Treatment
- Modalities, Technology, and Instrumentation
- Population and Systems

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The “Double-Empathy Problem”

Communication between same neurotype

From neurotypical to neurotypical
From autistic to autistic

Efficient

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Different neurotype

From neurotypical to autistic
From autistic to neurotypical

Not efficient

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Step 1: Assessment

- Current demands:
 - What expectations are placed on them by parents? Teachers? Peers?
- Current receptive skill(s):
 - Do they know the expectation?
 - Can they differentiate between expected and unexpected?
- Current expressive skill(s):
 - Do they engage in the expected behavior?
 - If so, how consistently?
 - If not, is it by willful choice, or by inability (incl. barriers such as emotional regulation...)
- Data collection
 - Standardized assessment (e.g., CASL-2 Pragmatic Language, SLDT)
 - Parent, teacher, and self-evaluation checklists
 - Structured observation

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Step 2: Goal-setting

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Old-fashioned goals

- Sustained eye contact
- Whole-body listening
- Maintaining conversational exchanges for 3+ turns
- Talking about topics other than special interests

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Step 2: ND-affirming goals

- Communication!
- Self-advocacy
- Safety
 - Stranger-danger
 - Recognizing dishonesty
 - Recognizing harmful intent
- Problem-solving
- Identifying different perspectives
 - Approaching "Interpreting perspectives" with a double-empathy lens
- Goals set *with* client

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Collaborative goalsetting



Collaborative goals for communicative life participation in Aphasia: The FOURC model

- https://pubs.asha.org/doi/10.1044/2018_AJSLP-18-0163

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Step 3: Systematic tx

1. Explicit instruction
2. Discrimination between expected and unexpected
3. Modeling
4. Practicing in isolation
5. Practicing in context

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Step 3: Systematic tx

1. **Explicit instruction**
 - Teach the skill!
 - Provide context. How will it help them? Connect to individual goals, real-life applications.
 - Consider the framing—you're not teaching them "the right way," you're helping them understand others, and possibly equipping them with strategies and knowledge that they can *choose* to use.
2. Discrimination between expected and unexpected
3. Modeling
4. Practicing in isolation
5. Practicing in context

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Step 3: Systematic tx

1. Explicit instruction
2. **Discrimination between expected and unexpected**
 - Recognizing how "most people" do it
 - Contrasting against their own approach
 - Identifying and labeling differences
3. Modeling
4. Practicing in isolation
5. Practicing in context

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Step 3: Systematic tx

1. Explicit instruction
2. Discrimination between expected and unexpected
3. **Modeling**
 - Peer models
 - Video models
 - ...
 - Adult models
4. Practicing in isolation
5. Practicing in context

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Step 3: Systematic tx

1. Explicit instruction
2. Discrimination between expected and unexpected
3. Modeling
4. **Practicing in isolation**
 - Role-play with SLP and/or small group
 - *Minimize this step!*
5. Practicing in context

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Step 3: Systematic tx

1. Explicit instruction
2. Discrimination between expected and unexpected
3. Modeling
4. Practicing in isolation
5. **Practicing in context**
 - Practice in real-life settings
 - Practice with real-life communication partners
 - Practice in challenging circumstances
 - *Emphasize this step!*

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Step 4: Reflection

- Clinician feedback at every step!
 - Positive *and* constructive feedback
- Self-reflection
 - Check in regularly, not just when things go poorly
 - What am I doing well? What didn't go well? Which strategies are helpful?
- Focus on goals, not isolated skills
 - Are other people responding the way I want them to respond?
 - Are these strategies helping me reach my goals?

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Goals & methods for children across ages

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Children in the pre-linguistic stage

- Goals:
 - Communication
 - Just communication
 - Really, social skills are *not* the priority here



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Preschoolers

- Goals:
 - Language & functional communication
 - Self-regulation, incl. identifying and meeting sensory needs
- Approaches:
 - Modeling meaningful language & interactions
 - Facilitating peer play (w/ NT & ND peers!)
 - Mediating conflict & confusion
- Contexts:
 - Child-directed play
 - Parallel & cooperative games/activities



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Elementary schoolers

- **Goals:**
 - Understanding expectations across different contexts (e.g., unwritten rules, hidden curriculum, various communication partners)
 - Skills needed for safety and self-advocacy
- **Approaches:**
 - Systematic instruction of expectations, contrasts, and strategies
- **Contexts:**
 - Fostering a community of like-minded peers
 - Board games (pref. cooperative!)
 - Wordless picture books



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Adolescents

- **Goals:**
 - Collaborative goalsetting—working towards activity/participation
 - Embracing autistic identity
- **Approaches:**
 - Systematic instruction
 - Metacognitive approach to strategy instruction
- **Contexts:**
 - Conversations about masking and autonomy
 - Self-reflection: Outcomes of actions and strategies



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Accessible “social groups”

- Organized by interests and relationships
 - Not by diagnosis
- Centered around activities, objects, or sensory experiences
- Sensory-inclusive spaces
- Rejection of neuro-normative demands
 - E.g., forced interaction
- Celebration of autistic social norms
 - Promote autistic identities and characteristics

Positively disrupting social groups: A neurodiversity-affirming glow-up

- <https://leader.pubs.asha.org/doi/10.1044/leader.FTR1e.30012025.first-person-autistic-slp.44>



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Misc. resources

- Social Thinking
 - <https://www.socialthinking.com/>
 - Free and paid resources
- Autism Level UP
 - <https://www.autismlevelup.com/>
 - Free resources
- SEA Bridges Learning
 - <https://bridgeslearningsystem.com/sea-bridge/>
 - Paid resources

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Questions?

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